

Renewing Materialism: Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala and the Hermeneutical Option for the Poor

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ABSTRACT: With Gianni Vattimo's late collaborative works with Santiago Zabala, Vattimo is proving to be not only a philosopher of emancipatory hermeneutics but also one who is making his own distinct contribution to liberation philosophy. This article critically explores Vattimo's liberationist weak thought in the context of the New Materialisms. Though Vattimo's post-metaphysical hermeneutics lacks the linkage with the natural sciences and eschews the development of a political ontology, which are both characteristic of the New Materialisms, his deliberate reactivation and rehabilitation of Marx by way of Heidegger eventuates in an expressed preferential option for the poor. This animating concern with what Vattimo and Zabala term "the discharge of capitalism" restores the original animating spirit of Marx's dialectical materialism and thus makes the political dimension latent in materialist thought explicit and provides a new species of the New Materialisms.

KEY WORDS: Gianni Vattimo, Santiago Zabala, weak thought, New Materialism, liberation philosophy, hermeneutic communism

It is well-established how Gianni Vattimo's signature contribution to hermeneutical philosophy in "weak thought" is not simply post-metaphysical, but involves a repudiation of metaphysics, both for its historic linkage with violent regimes of power and more subtly for its violent, exclusionary discourse.¹ As one of the principal philosophical theorists of postmodernism, he has championed the ways by which its characteristic "Babel-like pluralism" is more inclusionary, transparent, and open-ended, creating the cultural conditions for greater and more meaningful democratic participation.² Even more, he has explicitly linked nihilism with emancipation.³ This liberationist motif within

his work becomes even more pronounced in his late collaborative works with Santiago Zabala with an explicitness that makes him now not only a philosopher of emancipatory hermeneutics, but one who is making his own distinct contribution to liberation philosophy.⁴

Like the first generation of liberation theologians from South America, Vattimo comes to his work in liberation by way of a critical reappropriation of Karl Marx. This reappropriation of Marx will be developed more fully in the section that follows, but for now I want to begin this exploratory essay by raising a question regarding the legacy of Marx's dialectical materialism. As critical theory, Continental philosophy, and contemporary religious thought are undergoing what has been termed a "material turn," the so-called New Materialisms have sought to distance themselves from what has been considered the crude, reductionist scientific positivism and economic determinism of Marx's approach. In stark contrast to the old materialist depictions of nature that were atomistic and mechanical, the New Materialism draws on the insights of general relativity, quantum mechanics, complexity theory, astrophysics and neuroscience to suggest not only the indeterminacy, interdependence and open-endedness of nature, but also an expanded sense of agency beyond the human, a non-anthropological view of agency that speaks of what Karen Barad has called the "entanglement of matter and meaning," and what Jane Bennet has termed "vibrant matter."⁵

In addition, the New Materialisms have been integral to the political turn in contemporary theory. More to the point, a growing number of Continental thinkers have consolidated around the argument for how the post-metaphysical, deconstructive approach to politics is lacking in a sufficient concept of the political. This has contributed to the burgeoning discourse in political theology that critically engages the significance of Carl Schmitt's work as one of the first sustained and most far-ranging critiques of modern liberalism. But whereas Schmitt's concept of the political rests on the friend-enemy distinction that restores the centrality of sovereignty in accordance with the uniform logic of the one, and as such is seen by many as dangerously antagonistic and at odds with the insights and commitments that have emerged from the political philosophies in the deconstructive, post-metaphysical mode, the New Materialisms provide a basis for an alternative concept of the political.⁶ As Diane Coole and Samantha Frost write in their excellent introduction to the New Materialisms, this alternative conception of the political emerges from "the sense that the radicalism of the dominant discourses which have flourished under the cultural turn is now more or less exhausted."⁷ Exhausted, but not repudiated or disavowed, what the New Materialisms provide is a way to relink cultural studies with the natural sciences, and thereby develop a fundamental political ontology.

These important developments within the disparate voices of the New Materialisms raise certain questions for this exploration of Vattimo. For instance, we

might ask whether Vattimo's liberationist philosophy belongs to the new or old materialism? Likewise, given the centrality the natural sciences have played not only in the development of a political ontology, but also in the development of a new materialist metaphysics, we might ask whether Vattimo's signature notion of the weakening of being might still be genuinely materialist at all? It is this second question, in particular, that brings me to this essay's main argument. Vattimo's late-developing liberationist philosophy, especially in reference to the collaborative work with Santiago Zabala in *Hermeneutic Communism*, marks both the political becoming of hermeneutics and a new species of the New Materialisms. Like the more scientifically and metaphysically inclined works and thinkers that have been identified with this still emerging school, Vattimo's new materialism is also non-reductive. What sets Vattimo's New Materialism apart is the deliberate way by which he and Zabala have sought to retrieve and rehabilitate Marx by way of Heidegger. In so doing, they provide what would otherwise be a missing dimension to the New Materialisms' politics—namely, an expressed preferential option for the poor.

We might put this in terms of an apparent paradox: By his expressed preferential option for the poor, Vattimo's liberationist philosophy restores the original animating spirit of Marx's dialectical materialism. Set within a context not only of radical indeterminacy, material entanglements, and hyper-partisanship, this is a new materialist retrieval of the ethico-political dimension of materialism that is genuinely non-reductive in so far as it is open-ended and in question.

THE POLITICAL BECOMING OF HERMENEUTICS

In his book, *The Reckless Minds: Intellectuals in Politics*, Mark Lilla rehearses the familiar condemnation of Heidegger for his association with the Nazi Party. For Lilla, Heidegger is just one of many contemporary intellectuals who have no business commenting on, or involving themselves in, politics. Better to avoid the political sphere altogether than run the risk of the philosophical love of wisdom degenerating into what Lilla terms a philotyranny. And not just Heidegger: for Lilla modern European history is replete with other examples of philosophers betraying the ideals of freedom and intellectual inquiry, in league with totalitarian regimes, and so utterly deluded that they fail philosophy's first and most enduring test—to tame the passions. The lesson of the twentieth century especially is how the temptation of the philotyrannical mind operates by an internal force that, in the words of Lilla, blinds by “the allure of an idea.”⁸ This sordid recent history is posed in contrast to the philosophical ideal as held by Socrates and Plato wherein it is doubtful whether the demands of politics and philosophy can ever be made to coincide.

In contrast to Lilla, Vattimo and Zabala accomplish the nearly unthinkable task, not only taking on the mantle of Heidegger for their entirely original and

sorely needed articulation of the meaning of the politics of hermeneutics, but convincingly demonstrating that a truly Heideggerian politics would be communist, not fascist. In so doing, Vattimo and Zabala not only reinvigorate the politics of the left, but even more, redefine and redirect philosophical hermeneutics. As such, *Hermeneutic Communism* is the first salvo in the political becoming of hermeneutics. In this work, they make the case that interpretation is necessarily a political act. And by philosophically reflecting on the nature of interpretation, a particular, if not certain, politics is bequeathed: a reinvigorated communism severed from its metaphysical foundations, an antifoundationalist and postmetaphysical politics that eschews violence, a weak Marxism that by its “South American alternative” aims to dissolve the Euro-American death grip on geopolitics.

There are two broad points that must be made here with regard to this bold project. First, along with other recent works in critical philosophy, Vattimo and Zabala have paved the way not so much for a demythologization of Heidegger that reads Heidegger against himself in order to salvage what is good and enduring from the shame of his Nazi involvement, but an actual invocation of Heidegger’s hermeneutical philosophy as a potential political model, an actual claim—however counterintuitive it might seem—that a properly Heideggerian politics would be a communistic one.⁹

Vattimo and Zabala invoke Heidegger as a source for political resistance against the machinery of capitalism and the way by which capitalism divvies out the winners and losers in the global economy. The logic of capitalism sets the powerful against the weak, whether on the scale of the neoliberal geopolitical order in terms of nation-states or for individuals. Whether we recognize it or not, this is a state of emergency, but it is left to the weak and dispossessed to sound the alarm when entrenched power is invested in preserving the status quo. In this way, the weak, postmetaphysical thought of hermeneutics “becomes the thought of the weak in search of alternatives.” It is a weak form of thought that does not claim universality and “does not believe that politics can be founded on scientific and rational grounds, but only on interpretation, history, and event.”¹⁰

By *reading Heidegger into Marx* and thereby posing the possibility of a hermeneutic communism, they correct Marxist philosophies of their own excesses—or more precisely, purge Marxism of its metaphysical bearings. The fault with Marxism, according to Vattimo and Zabala, is not its revolutionary charge to change the world but that it framed this demand for change “within the metaphysical tradition.”¹¹ Accordingly, they set aside the general call for revolution in lieu of a more basic defense of the weak. They admit that this strategy of reading backwards—“from Heidegger to Marx”—goes “further than Marx or Heidegger intended.”¹² Nevertheless, by so doing, they articulate a conception of a “communism of the twenty-first century,” or a “weakened communism.” This would be a humbled communism that takes its distance from both the historical Soviet and

the contemporary Chinese models. It is humbled by the hermeneutical attitude that must always contend with the conflict of interpretations and that thus places a premium on respect for differences. And as a hermeneutic communism, it is also necessarily a democratic communism, but not the reigning democracy that has made the fateful mistake of conflating freedom with free markets and which has felt justified in spreading democracy by the barrel of a gun—the prevailing neoliberal order Vattimo and Zabala describe in terms of “framed democracy” and “armed capitalism.” Though humbled, this hermeneutic communism still presents itself if not the last, then at least the best, hope for the global poor—or in Vattimo and Zabala’s terms, the “discharge of capitalism.”¹³

The audacity in this work is how it cites Heidegger as an ally. After all, the case against Heidegger is well established. The argument from Karl Löwith that Heidegger’s Nazism “was not born of a regrettable miscue” but is consistent with—indeed, a necessary outgrowth of—his existentialism, has set the agenda. It was in a 1936 conversation with Löwith, after all, that Heidegger agreed “without reservation” that “his partisanship for National Socialism lay in the essence of his philosophy.”¹⁴ So in the words of Richard Wolin, “We know that Heidegger’s alliance with Nazism, far from being a temporary marriage of convenience, was grandiose and profound: at least for a short period of time, Heidegger labored under the delusion that he could play the role of ‘philosopher-king’ to Hitler’s *Führersstaat* ... so that the ‘National Revolution’ might fulfill its appointed metaphysical destiny.”¹⁵

Likewise, it is well known how Heidegger repudiated communism. But Vattimo and Zabala argue that this repudiation was not an outgrowth of his early Nazi sympathies, “but rather because of his need to overcome metaphysics.”¹⁶ As evidence of this, they site his simultaneous repudiation of Western style democracy and free-market capitalism. By their reading, Heidegger was trying to think politics otherwise. The problem with the existing forms of communism, capitalism, and democracy is that they all strived to complete a “metaphysical organization of beings,” and in so doing, failed the thought of Being, and failed to acknowledge “philosophy’s groundless realm.”¹⁷ As a post-metaphysical thinker of Being, one whose philosophical project was defined by the quest to overcome metaphysics, this is the key to thinking Heidegger’s politics otherwise; this is the “other” Heidegger who can be claimed as a political ally in the articulation of a hermeneutic communism in spite of his protestations to the contrary.

By the hermeneutical strategy of reading backwards—from Heidegger to Marx—not only a new politics, but a potentially new concept of the political, emerges. The politics is a new communism for the twenty-first century, one that is weakened, if not cured, of its metaphysical foundations wherein communism might once again—even if for the very first time—defend the interests, and stand in solidarity with, the weakest citizens. But this only gets us partway to the answer regarding whether a post-metaphysical philosophy can produce a positive

politics at all, or whether postmetaphysics always and necessarily must remain only in a deconstructive mode.

This brings me to the second broad point raised in connection with *Hermeneutic Communism*, which is the methodological question regarding the connection between hermeneutics and politics. While it seems clear that Vattimo and Zabala's project is intended as an effort to revitalize the radical politics of the Left, it is simultaneously a work in critical philosophy. In making the case for the political becoming of hermeneutics, it is not just staking its claim within the history of hermeneutical philosophy, but also providing its very own critique and corrective to that history. Their claim is not simply that hermeneutics might be applied to politics, but a much stronger one: hermeneutics properly understood eventuates in a particular form of politics, specifically a communism of and for the twenty-first century. This is a departure from the way their post-metaphysical hermeneutics of weak thought has typically been portrayed.

Perhaps the most comprehensive and damning critiques of the postmetaphysical tradition comes from the famed British left-wing literary critic Terry Eagleton in his book from 1996, *The Illusions of Postmodernism*.¹⁸ Eagleton has criticized postmodernism by noting how its presumed radical ideas of negativity and undecidability are in actuality an announcement of political defeat by the left—a form of micropolitics and political subjectivity perfectly in concert with, and thus completely unable to resist, the cultural logic of late capitalism. After all, as Eagleton points out, “Capitalism is the most pluralistic order history has ever known.” Thus by relativizing capitalism as just one other form of totality among others, by refusing to organize itself in an explicitly anti-capitalist fashion, postmodernism has effectively pulled out the rug from beneath itself. For instance, in a characteristic passage, Eagleton writes:

For in a period when no far-reaching political action seems really feasible, when so-called micropolitics seems the order of the day, it is relieving to convert this necessity into a virtue—to persuade oneself that one's political limits have, as it were, a solid ontological grounding, in the fact that social totality is in any case a chimera. It doesn't matter if there is no political agent on hand to transform the whole, since there is in fact no whole to be transformed. It is as though, having mislaid the breadknife, one declares the loaf to be already sliced.¹⁹

More bluntly, and more directly to the point of Vattimo and Zabala's hermeneutic theory, Eagleton questions the political value and viability of a postmetaphysical epistemology wherein everything is subject to interpretation. “Everything would become an interpretation,” Eagleton writes as he narrates the philosophical genealogy of postmodernism, “including that claim itself, in which case the idea of interpretation would cancel all the way through and leave everything exactly as it was. A radical epistemology would issue, conveniently enough,

in a conservative politics.”²⁰ It is with this in mind that Eagleton announces his overall assessment of postmodernism. He writes variously that “it is the upshot of a political failure” or “the backwash of a political debacle,” which has left the so-called left in a state of “political illiteracy and historical oblivion” and the power of capital never “so sublimely omnipotent and omnipresent.”²¹

Put schematically, the problem with postmodernism, especially the post-metaphysical postmodernism to which Vattimo and Zabala subscribe, is a political problem. It is a political problem because its actual politics is in fact a form of post-politics, a politics of evasion that has sidestepped the most vital and intractable political problem of our time—namely, the presumed naturalism of capitalism, and concomitantly, its nearly total, and totally unresisted, spread. While much of postmodern discourse has effectively historicized normative values and operative ideologies, Eagleton is correct to point out that historicizing in and of itself is not necessarily a radical act, and most definitely does not belong to the left alone. Postmodernism might very well be oppositional, but it is a *framed opposition* allowing for a nearly infinite multiplicity, but with no sustained and targeted critique of the lone governing logic that keeps those multiplicities in a perpetual and almost purposeful state of play—“politically oppositional but economically complicit” is how Eagleton concludes his critique.²²

Eagleton’s critique is a potent, but generalized, one. Kenneth Surin provides a much more fine-grained analysis of what we might term postmodern politics in his article, “The Ontological Script of Liberation.”²³ He begins with an acknowledgement of how the transnational flow of capital operates as a sovereign power, and how the modern model of the secular nation state is powerless to control or hold accountable the new regimes of capitalist accumulation. In the era of globalization our economy has become global but our political institutions have not. This has weakened or neutralized state power and contributed to a post-political citizenry. Citing his colleague Fredric Jameson, Surin argues that this apparent triumph of global capital is so dire, or so complete, that “it’s easier for us nowadays to contemplate the total destruction of the earth through some ecological catastrophe than it is to believe that capitalism will come to an end.”²⁴

In the wake of this, Surin outlines four contemporary political options for the left: The first option is the politics of identity, which Surin promptly dismisses for how smoothly it dovetails into actually existing capitalism. The second, which he associates with the ethico-political deconstructive work of Derrida and Levinas, is the politics of subjectivity. For Surin, the politics of subjectivity becomes an unwitting politics of decision. Further, “it has no way of inserting the subject into the domain of the actually political,” and as a consequence, “provides no way of imagining resistance at the level of a politics of collective action.”²⁵ The third option is labeled as the politics of the Event, associated with Alain Badiou and Slavoj Žižek. This option is the most fervently anticapitalist contemporary mode

of political resistance, but it also might be guilty of a kind of political romanticism. Further, because it is predicated on the notion of a truth-event as a radical rupture, it is incapable of providing any norms whatsoever. The state of exception which Badiou and Žižek might seize upon in order to mobilize anticapitalist resistance might just as easily and more frequently be mobilized by the right as a justification for a seizure of state power that violates constitutional norms and limitations as was seen in the aftermath of 9/11. This leaves the fourth and final option for Surin, which is the politics of the multitude, identified with Deleuze and Guattari, as well as with Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri. The virtue of multitude theory, as described by Surin, is how it conceives of political power as autogenerating. In Surin's words, "the multitude directs itself according to its own powers and its own history."²⁶ It is a decentralized form of political power befitting a polycentric world. At the same time, it recognizes the logic of the global flow of capital as a transnational sovereignty.

By now, it should be abundantly clear how on nearly every count Vattimo and Zabala have risen to Eagleton's sweeping challenge, and in so doing, provide a fifth option for organizing the contemporary politics of the left to the four as outlined by Surin. As a liberationist philosophy with an expressed preferential option for the poor, Vattimo and Zabala have taken the hermeneutical theory of interpretation and given it a fully fleshed political body. Theirs is no politics of evasion. It is oppositional, without being economically complicit. On the contrary, its chief theoretical opposition comes by virtue of its concept of a "framed democracy." That is, a democracy in name only, a democracy held hostage by a neoliberal economic policy that continues to divide the world between haves and have-nots divvying out the winners and losers of globalization.

Eagleton has accused postmodernism of only a framed opposition, by which he means that the single most vital political question is left entirely out of the equation. This would not only be a politics of evasion, but also rightly a politics of defeat. Vattimo and Zabala have put the picture back in the frame; they have accomplished a political becoming of hermeneutics. If Vattimo and Zabala are correct, what our politics need is not less hermeneutics, but more—and the more hermeneutical our politics, the more even communism itself can deliver on its own liberationist promise.

A RENEWED MATERIALISM

This work on the part of Vattimo and Zabala has been simultaneous with the larger political turn in contemporary theory. The New Materialisms, in particular, have grown out of the "exhaustion" with the existing political alternatives within contemporary theory. Perhaps most significant, especially in terms of the contrast it strikes with Vattimo's weak thought, is the way by which the New Materialisms

have contributed to the development of a new political ontology relinking cultural studies with the natural sciences. In this way, the various New Materialisms can be seen as an effort to critique and combat the biopolitical order of late capitalism.

Take the work of Catherine Malabou, for instance: Malabou belongs together with figures such as Alain Badiou, the speculative realists, and the new materialists in suggesting an alternative to a purely linguistic philosophy. But whereas Badiou and the speculative realists directly repudiate the paradigm of philosophies of language, Malabou reads textuality as a materiality, thereby retaining the flux and indeterminacy associated with Derridian deconstruction, but not by way of an indifference to the natural sciences and/or a repudiation of essence. Instead, Malabou demonstrates, for instance, how neurobiology, properly understood, teaches us that the brain has a history—that it is in part constituted by its experience, but also is in the permanent, never-ending state of constituting itself. The brain, and not just the mind, is adaptable. This is a non-reductive materialism that provides profound implications for the nature of human freedom, moral responsibility, and the individual's relationship to society.

In perhaps what has been her most noteworthy claim—or the analogy that first brought her widespread critical attention—in *What Should We Do With Our Brain?* Malabou analogizes from the neurobiological to the biopolitical.²⁷ That is to say, how we think of our brain both reflects and partly determines our social and political world. Neurobiological reality is just as much a biopolitical reality. She claims that a neuronal ideology blinds us to the actual nature of brain plasticity, an ideology that, throughout the early part of the twentieth century, when industrial capitalism in the West was at its peak, stubbornly mistook the brain as a machine or as a control center. This faulty understanding of the brain pairs up with an industrial mindset and managerial regime wherein the worker is the subject of control and domination. With shifts to a post-industrial economy in the West, however, this neuronal ideology has undergone a shift—the brain as command-center or machine gives way to a faulty understanding of plasticity wherein plasticity is reduced to pure flexibility. In Malabou's words, "flexibility is plasticity minus its genius."²⁸

The genius here refers to the dual aspect of plasticity—that is, the concept of plasticity means not just the capacity to receive form or to be acted upon, but also, the capacity to give form or to resist. So the current neuronal ideology gets it only half right. The brain is not a fixed entity. It retains this permanent capacity to open up new neuronal pathways, to adjust to certain traumas, and to actualize almost an infinitude of possibilities. The brain demonstrates a remarkable resiliency and flexibility, adjusting and responding to almost any environment. Likewise the worker in a post-industrial economy—the worker is nomadic. To thrive in today's global economy, the worker must be willing and able to adjust to new market demands, adjust to the rapid pace of change, learn and relearn new

skills and capacities. As such, it is a biopolitics of extreme flexibility that renders the subject almost entirely pliant, a blob of clay that can be molded and remolded at the market's whims.

But, this is only one half of plasticity. Malabou draws a hard line differentiating between flexibility and adaptability. What differentiates them is the fact that the latter retains its resistance. Our current neuronal ideology blinds us to the possibility of resistance because such agency runs counter to the demands of a global workforce. If the plasticity of the brain is misconstrued only as a flexibility, then this naturalizes and thus justifies all forms of the dislocation and exploitation of labor. The analysis here is akin to that offered by Antonio Gramsci in that the regime of control functions not by way of overt force or coercion, but by the power of cultural hegemony. Also useful to understand here is the analysis of contemporary forms of alienation as detailed by the Italian theorist of post-industrial capitalism Franco Berardi, wherein

Under these conditions *privacy* and its possibilities are abolished. . . .

Everywhere, attention is under siege.

Not silence but uninterrupted noise, not Antoninioni's *red desert*, but a cognitive space overloaded with nervous incentives to act: this is the alienation of our times.²⁹

Malabou goes one step further: this captivity must be understood to be not only ideological, but material—because, after all, the mind is nothing other than the brain.

This is the contemporary crisis of political subjectivity, and what is desperately needed, according to Malabou, is a reschematized philosophy of freedom founded on a thoroughly materialized notion of resistance. Put otherwise, a materialized notion of resistance demonstrates resistance as a necessary part of nature, not as a form of defiance against it. The adaptability of the brain is the material means by which the self achieves its auto-constitution. But adaptability is not flexibility, and so this auto-constitution, in the words of Malabou “cannot be conceived as a simple adaptation to a form, to a mold, or to the received schemata of a culture.” She describes the plasticity of the self in terms of “a necessary split and the search for an equilibrium between the preservation of constancy . . . and the exposure of this constancy to accidents, to the outside, to otherness in general.” Being does not operate by a steady-state principle. Instead, in the words of Malabou, “What results is a tension born of the resistance that constancy and creation mutually oppose to each other. It is thus that every form carries within itself its own contradiction. And precisely this resistance makes transformation possible.”³⁰ Resistance is not reactionary, but generative, not restorative of an equilibrium, but constitutive of form. As such, it is integral, not opposed, to nature.

Not only does the plasticity of the brain reveal resistance as integral to the self-formation of the natural and biological themselves, but it also shows how we are blinded by a certain neuronal ideology that naturalizes flexibility and thereby gives credence to and reinforces a purely pliant subject who is entirely victim to a supposed natural, though no less savage, order of consumption. Such an ideology would make us into mere pawns of capital, confining us to a fate of endless and nomadic laboring in which our only tangible asset is our pliancy, and hence, our docility. But as Malabou shows us, just at the brain *needs* resistance, so too does society. Resistance to this supposed natural order is no more unnatural than it is unwanted: “*Creating resistance to neuronal ideology is what our brain wants, and what we want for it.*”³¹

While Malabou develops a materialist philosophy of freedom, she is not a liberationist philosopher per se. It is in this respect that Vattimo and Zabala renew materialism by restoring its original ethico-political spirit. To make this case, I draw on Tamsin Jones’s introduction to the volume, *Religious Experience and New Materialism*, in which she identifies both the sources and common themes of the New Materialisms.³² Jones shows how the New Materialisms first emerged out of a critical shift in feminist theory, specifically in reference to essentialism.³³ In addition, as indicated above, the development of the New Materialisms is coincident with that of Speculative Realism in that both mark a shift from philosophies of language to an immanent metaphysical realism. And lastly, the New Materialisms accomplish a philosophical rapprochement with the natural sciences whereby quantum mechanics and the theory of entanglement break down the traditional mind/matter dualism.

When considering each of these sources of the New Materialisms as named by Jones, Vattimo and Zabala fall outside the New Materialist trajectory. However, it is when she comes to the four common themes that we can see how Vattimo and Zabala’s work can be mapped onto the New Materialisms in such a way that the particular liberationist contribution they make can be best appreciated. The first of these Jones describes in terms of the “fatigue and dissatisfaction with the inherent limits of theory dominated by the cultural and linguistic turn.” The previous section has already shown how Vattimo and Zabala’s *Hermeneutic Communism* might be seen as the political becoming of hermeneutics, and thus as a critique and correction to that strand of deconstructive, post-metaphysical philosophy.

Second, Jones points out how the New Materialists are self-aware in locating themselves at “the tail end of postmodernity.” But unlike other philosophical movements of this moment, they are neither neo-traditionalists nor scientific positivists. On the contrary, they remain “explicitly open-ended and indeterminate,” thus revivifying a conception of freedom that does not just apply to human subjects, but to all material phenomena. This theme of freedom has long been central to Vattimo’s understanding of hermeneutics. What he adds in his collabora-

tion with Zabala is what they call the “ethico-political problem of emancipation.”³⁴ This problem presents itself in terms of an opposition between metaphysics and hermeneutics wherein metaphysics legitimates hegemony by virtue of its positing of an independent objective order to which human knowledge and action must conform. Hermeneutics, by contrast—especially hermeneutics as weak thought—“is an interpretative response to the end of metaphysics.” They describe hermeneutics in terms of an “interested involvement” that is “against objectivity,” that denotes “the abandonment of pretensions to absolutes,” and that “reveals itself as emancipative.”³⁵ But even more than this standard deconstructive, post-metaphysical characterization that aptly describes the postmodern condition, Vattimo and Zabala write this philosophical debate in terms of a political struggle for freedom: the end of metaphysics is rewritten as the condition of possibility for emancipation. As they write, “It is important to emphasize that the negative connotation of the term ‘weak’ does not allude to a failure of thinking as such but rather to the consequences of the transformation of thought brought about by the end of metaphysics, hence as a possibility of emancipation.”³⁶

Third, Jones points to the New Materialists’ insistence on “not just the significance, but also the *agency*, of the material world.” And fourth, she writes of the rejection of “any claim or appeal to transcendence in favor of an entirely immanent system of thought.” The subject-object divide that renders matter as inert has been dissolved in favor of “vibrant matter.” This expanded conception of agency has had important implications for environmental philosophy, leading to a shift from anthropocentrism to ecocentrism and the positing of the “earth as subject.”³⁷ It also radically displaces what Walter D. Mignolo has termed the “ego-politics of knowledge” wherein not just the human subject is treated as the foundation of knowledge, but a very particular—e.g., modern, Western, male, white, etc.—human subject has been elevated as sovereign lord.³⁸

We might resituate these third and fourth themes in terms of the question not only of *who* thinks, but also of *where* thinking happens. In this way, the common theme of the New Materialisms is the mattering of matter—or more precisely, the question of what matter matters. It is this question which is at the heart of the Black Lives Matter movement that has recently emerged in direct response to the 2012 killing of Trayvon Martin and as a call to action against all extrajudicial killings of African Americans. While this incident was the original spark to Black Lives Matter, the movement has since grown to be a larger critique of the systemic racism endemic to the American criminal justice system. To say that Black Lives Matter is to acknowledge the ongoing racial oppression that has rendered African Americans invisible and powerless in the face of disproportionate and massive incarceration. It is to reclaim the value of black bodies rendered invisible and lifeless by police violence. To matter is to have agency. To hearken back to Malabou, it is a movement of resilience and resistance, not docility and flexibility.

To say what matter matters is to make a claim of value. It is in this way that we can read Black Lives Matter analogously to Vattimo and Zabala's invocation of "The South American Alternative." They write, "Weak thought can only be the thought of the weak, certainly not of the dominant classes, who have always worked to conserve and leave unquestioned the established order of the world."³⁹ The clear suggestion here is not only that hermeneutic communism expresses a preferential option for the poor, but that weak thought is the philosophical voice of resistance articulated by the marginalized and oppressed. It is the particular political power that belongs to the dispossessed. By invoking "The South American Alternative," they have not only sought to recenter contemporary political philosophy, but they have made a gesture towards the "decolonial option" within contemporary theory. The Global South matters for Vattimo and Zabala as an alternative to the "framed democracies" and "armed capitalism" that provide the basis for the neoliberal consensus. The Global South functions as an externality to the modern colonial matrix of power by virtue of its own archive of knowledge. To Vattimo and Zabala, the political success of South American resistance is like a specter haunting the apparent triumph of global capital.

While this turn towards the Global South might not speak of the agency of matter itself, and neither does it escape the decolonial critique by Mignolo of "Third world thoughts . . . processed in European intellectual factories," summarizing from Mignolo with regard to the distinction between post-colonialism and the decolonial, I would argue they "walk in the same direction, following different paths."⁴⁰ Where Vattimo once spoke of the coincidence, or parallel history, of the weakening of being and the secularization of Christianity, here he speaks of the coincidence of the concentration of capital and the growth of slums as the indispensable containers for global capitalism's waste. By invoking the global poor and by attending to the urban slums, Vattimo and Zabala have reformed communism by renewing its once professed solidarity with those whom they call the "discharge of capitalism." These are "the weak, poor, and oppressed" who "exist at history's margins."⁴¹ But following the script of the vibrant agency that exists within matter itself, Vattimo and Zabala insist that they are decidedly not inert, but offer up "different forms of resistance" that "are the most productive alternatives at our disposal today."⁴²

To penetrate through the global defenses requires an exterior point of origination that changes both *who* partakes in the conversation and also the very *terms* of the conversation. It is in this way that the decolonial option provides an epistemological and ontological alternative. "I am where I think" is the slogan Mignolo gives to this alternative epistemology and ontology, a repudiation of the presumed universality of the modern Cartesian subject.⁴³ This is an epistemology of dwelling that does not simply make reference to local habitats and cultures, but is fully immersed. The accompanying political ontology acknowledges and provides for

overlapping and conflicting spheres of sovereignty, and different possibilities for conceiving of what counts as a person and what or whom is deserving of rights as determined by bonds of mutual obligation and care. To make place central to epistemology and ontology is to put a lie to the universal code proffered by the West. Place matters. And when place matters, it is not just one single place, but different places, different peoples—*from the universal to the pluriversal*. It neither claims universality for itself, nor does it appeal to transcendence. Exterior, but not transcendent, the South American alternative provides another option for imagining a global future that escapes the Euro-American stranglehold on geopolitics, an option that does not so much depend on the internal confrontation of the West with itself as it does on exploring alternative genealogies of thought and practice. It seeks a horizon of thinking outside the West but that nevertheless—or perhaps precisely thereby—recognizes the “darker side of Western modernity.”

CONCLUSION

What I have sought to argue in this exploratory essay is that Vattimo and Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism* offers a new materialism that goes by a different name—namely, that of liberation. Like its kin in Liberation Theology, it is a political articulation that walks a delicate tightrope. It seeks to politicize what was heretofore an essentially apolitical discourse. Liberation Theology accomplished this by developing a thoroughgoing critique of traditional forms of Christian thought and practice for their otherworldly spiritualism. Vattimo and Zabala accomplish this by developing the political becoming of hermeneutics, making the argument that a positive political commitment to the poor and the oppressed does not violate the open-ended and indeterminate nature of hermeneutical interpretation. Likewise, both Liberation Theology and Vattimo and Zabala's developing liberation philosophy critically appropriate Marx, both for his systematic analysis of the exploitation and alienation caused by capital's apparent triumph and for his clear-eyed focus on class struggle as the engine of history. It is this understanding of class struggle that provides the material basis not only for his expressed politics, but also for his political ontology.

So while Vattimo and Zabala's work remains post-metaphysical, and as such falls outside the purview or works against the grain of the various other New Materialisms, it is not without a certain political ontology. Hermeneutics becomes political when it articulates its preferential option for the poor, even as weak thought is named as the particular political power of resistance that belongs to the poor. It is in this way that Vattimo and Zabala's emerging liberation theology provides a new species of the New Materialisms by restoring its ethico-political spirit.

NOTES

1. For instance, Vattimo explains that “I define [metaphysics] as the violent imposition of an order that is declared objective and natural and therefore cannot be violated and is no longer an object of discussion. . . . If you admit there is a first principle that can be grasped and known in a definite way, you prevent anybody from ever asking again. So, on this basis, I have developed the following theory with regard to violence. As I have explained in *Nihilism and Emancipation*, violence is the fact of shutting down, silencing, breaking off the dialogue of questions and answers. This is what ultimate foundations do; they impose themselves as impervious to further questions as objects of contemplation and *amor dei intellectualis*.” In John D. Caputo and Gianni Vattimo, *After the Death of God*, ed. Jeffrey W. Robbins (New York: Columbia University Press, 2007), 93.
2. The phrase “Babel-like pluralism” is used by Vattimo to describe the cultural fragmentation of late-modern society and as the “verification” of the death of God and the end of metaphysics. See Gianni Vattimo, *After Christianity*, trans. Luca D’Isanto (New York: Columbia University Press, 2002), 15. For Vattimo’s most explicit theorization of the postmodern condition, see Gianni Vattimo, *The Transparent Society* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1992).
3. See Gianni Vattimo, *Nihilism and Emancipation: Ethics, Politics, and Law*, trans. William McCuaig (New York: Columbia University Press, 2004).
4. See Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism: From Heidegger to Marx* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2011).
5. See Karen Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway: Quantum Physics and the Entanglement of Matter and Meaning* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2007), and Jane Bennett, *Vibrant Matter: A Political Ecology of Things* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2010).
6. For my fully developed critique of the anti-democratic nature of Schmitt’s political theology, see Jeffrey W. Robbins, *Radical Democracy and Political Theology* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2011).
7. Diane Coole and Samantha Frost, eds., *New Materialisms: Ontology, Agency and Politics* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2010), 6.
8. Mark Lilla, *The Reckless Mind: Intellectuals in Politics* (New York: New York Review Books, 2001), 216.
9. For instance, see Catherine Malabou, *The Heidegger Change: On the Fantastic in Philosophy*, trans. Peter Skafish (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2011). By contrast, see Peter Trawny, *Heidegger and the Myth of a Jewish World Conspiracy*, trans. Andrew J. Mitchell (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2016), which mines Heidegger’s *Black Notebooks* to show the centrality of anti-Semitism to his developing philosophy during the years of World War II.
10. Vattimo and Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism*, 2–3.
11. *Ibid.*, 1.
12. *Ibid.*, 4.
13. *Ibid.*, 50.
14. Quoted in *The Heidegger Controversy: A Critical Reader*, ed. Richard Wolin (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1998), 4.

15. Ibid., 2.
16. Vattimo and Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism*, 4.
17. Ibid., 5.
18. Terry Eagleton, *The Illusions of Postmodernism* (London: Blackwell, 1996).
19. Ibid., 9.
20. Ibid., 14.
21. Ibid., 21–23.
22. Ibid., 132.
23. Kenneth Surin, “Rewriting the Ontological Script of Liberation,” in *Theology and the Political: The New Debate*, ed. Creston Davis, John Milbank, and Slavoj Žizek (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2005), 240–66.
24. Ibid., 252–53.
25. Ibid., 255.
26. Ibid., 257.
27. Catherine Malabou, *What Should We Do with Our Brain?*, trans. Sebastian Rand (New York: Fordham University Press, 2008).
28. Ibid., 12.
29. Franco Berardi, *The Soul at Work: From Alienation to Autonomy*, trans. Francesca Cadel and Giuseppina Mecchia (Los Angeles: Semiotext(e), 2009), 107–08.
30. Ibid., 71.
31. Ibid., 77; italics in original.
32. See *Religious Experience and New Materialism: Movement Matters*, ed. Joerg Rieger and Edward Waggoner (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2015).
33. Jones references Stacy Alaimo and Susan Hekman, eds., *Material Feminisms* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2008), and Linda Alcoff, “Philosophy Matters: A Review of Recent Work in Feminist Philosophy,” in *Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society* 25(3) (2000): 841–82. See also Catherine Malabou, *Changing Difference: The Feminine and the Question of Philosophy*, trans. Carolyn Shread (Malden, MA: Polity Press, 2011).
34. Vattimo and Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism*, 94.
35. Ibid., 96.
36. Ibid., 97.
37. For instance, see Clayton Crockett and Jeffrey W. Robbins, *Religion, Politics and the Earth: The New Materialism* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2012).
38. See Walter D. Mignolo, *The Darker Side of Western Modernity: Global Futures, Decolonial Options* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2011), xvi.
39. Vattimo and Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism*, 96.
40. Ibid., 57, 55.
41. Ibid., 50.
42. Ibid., 140.
43. Mignolo, *The Darker Side of Western Modernity*, xvi.